

The Colosseum

The largest amphitheatre ever built was constructed in Rome in 72–80 CE, to host public spectacles including gladiator fights, wild animal hunts and public executions. The Colosseum was part of a wider construction programme begun by Emperor Vespasian to restore Rome's glory prior to the recent civil war. Like nothing ever built, it dominated the city and became a symbol of Rome, its society and culture. Oval in shape, made from locally quarried travertine stone, brick, volcanic stone and pumice, it also featured concrete, then a recent invention. The Colosseum had four tiers, with 80 monumental open arcades on three of them, and statues in each. The first floor had Doric columns, the second Ionic, and the top floor featured Corinthian pilasters (column-like reliefs on walls) and small windows. On each tier, passages and corridors had vaulted concrete ceilings on limestone supports. At over 45 metres (150 ft) high and 545 metres (1,780 ft) in perimeter, the Colosseum held some 50,000 spectators, who could be evacuated in 15 minutes.

